

A Book for Boys and Girls

Or, Country Rhymes for Children

JOHN BUNYAN

NORTH PASS PRESS

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A Book for Boys and Girls

First Edition

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¹Spelled "lanthorn" in the original edition.

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A Note from the Publisher

John Bunyan's *A Book for Boys and Girls*—later popularized as *Divine Emblems*—was first published in 1686. For over three centuries, however, the majority of printed editions have been based on abridged or heavily edited versions that cut out significant portions of Bunyan's original poetry and his unique pedagogical framework.

This North Pass Press edition is, to our knowledge, the first modern typesetting to restore the 1686 original in its entirety. Unlike the more common *Divine Emblems* editions, which often omit more than half of the original poems, this volume preserves every verse of Bunyan's "homely rhymes." By returning to the source text, we allow the reader to experience the full scope of Bunyan's vision—one that is as much a manual for literacy as it is a treasury of spiritual emblems.

A centerpiece of this restoration is the inclusion of the "Appendix," which Bunyan designed as "An help to Children to learn to read English." By preserving the historic alphabets and font classifications exactly as they appeared in 1686, we invite the reader to experience the book as it was first intended: a comprehensive primer for the young and the "childish" alike.

Our editorial approach remains consistent with the North Pass mission: to provide a clean, modern typesetting that

respects the rhythmic gravity and idiosyncratic charm of the 17th-century original.

We commend this edition to the attention of all - whether a 'bearded boy' or not - who love the unadulterated words of those who walked in the old paths.

North Pass Press

2026

To the Reader

Courteous Reader,
The little page will show, if there thou look,
Who are the proper subjects of this book.
They're boys and girls of all sorts and degrees,
From those of age, to children on the knees.
Thus comprehensive am I in my notions;
They tempt me to it by their childish motions.
We now have boys with beards, and girls that be
Big as old women, wanting gravity.

Then do not blame me, 'cause I thus describe them;
Flatter I may not, lest thereby I bribe them
To have a better judgment of themselves,
Then wise men have of babies on their shelves.
Their antic tricks, fantastic modes, and way,
Show they like very boys, and girls, do play
With all the frantic fopp'ries of this age;
And that in open view, as on a stage;
Our bearded men, do act like beardless boys;
Our women please themselves with childish toys.

Our ministers, long time by word and pen,
Deal with them, counting them, not boys but men:
Thunderbolts they shot at them, and their toys:

But hit then not, 'cause they were girls and boys.
The better charge, the wider still they shot,
Or else so high, these dwarfs they touchéd not.
Instead of men, they found them girls and boys,
Addict to nothing as to childish toys.

Wherefore good Reader, that I save them may,
I now with them, the very dottril² play.
And since at gravity they make a tush,
My very beard I cast behind the bush.
And like a fool stand fing'ring of their toys;
And all to show them, they are girls and boys.

Nor do I blush, although I think some may
Call me a baby, 'cause I with them play:
I do't to show them how each fingle-fangle,
On which they doting are, their souls entangle,
As with a web, a trap, a gin, a snare:
And will destroy them, have they not a care.

Paul seemed to play the fool, that he might gain
Those that were fools indeed, if not in grain.
And did it by their things, that they might know
Their emptiness, and might be brought unto
What would them save from sin and vanity.
A noble act, and full of honesty.

Yet he, nor I would like them be in vice,
While by their play-things, I would them entice,
To mount their thoughts from what are childish toys,

²term used for those who imitate or are easily fooled

To Heav'n, for that's prepared for girls and boys.
Nor do I so confine myself to these,
As to shun graver things, I seek to please,
Those more composed with better things than toys:
Though thus I would be catching girls and boys.

Wherefore if men have now a mind to look;
Perhaps their greater fancies may be took
With what is here; though but in homely rhymes:
But he, who pleases all, must rise betimes.
Some, I persuade me, will be finding fault,
Concluding, here I trip, and there I halt,
No doubt some could these groveling notions raise
By fine-spun terms that challenge might the bays.
But should all men be forced to lay aside
Their brains, that cannot regulate the tide:
By this or that man's fancy, we should have
The wise, unto the fool, become a slave.
What though my text seems mean, my morals be
Grave, as if fetched from a sublimer tree.
And if some better handle can a fly,
Then some a text, why should we them deny
Their making proof, or good experiment,
Of smallest things great mischiefs to prevent?

Wise Solomon did fools to piss-ants³ send,
To learn true wisdom, and their lives to mend.
Yea, God by swallows, cuckoos, and the ass;
Shows they are fools who let that season pass,

³woodants whose mounds have a pungent smell

Which he put in their hand, that to obtain
Which is both present, and eternal gain.

I think the wiser sort my rhymes may slight
But what were I! The foolish will delight
To read them, and the foolish, God has chose.
And doth by foolish things, their minds compose,
And settle upon that which is divine:
Great things, by little ones, are made to shine.

I could, were I so pleased, use higher strains.
And for applause, on tenters stretch my brains,
But what needs that? The arrow out of sight,
Does not the sleeper, nor the watchman fright.
To shoot too high doth but make children gaze;
'Tis that which hits the man, doth him amaze.

And for the inconsiderableness
Of things, by which I do my mind express;
May I by them bring some good thing to pass,
As Sampson, with the jaw-bone of an ass;
Or as brave Shamgar with his ox's goad,
(Both things not manly, nor for war in mode)
I have my end, though I myself expose
To scorn; God will have glory in the close.

Thus much for artificial babes; and now
To those who are in years but such, I bow
My pen to teach them what the letter be,
And how they may improve their A, B, C.
Nor let my pretty children them despise;
All, needs must there begin, that would be wise.

Nor let them fall under discouragement,
Who at their horn-book stick, and time hath spent
Upon that A, B, C while others do
Into their primer, or their psalter go.
Some boys with difficulty do begin,
Who in the end, the bays, and laurel win.

– J. B.

A Book for Boys and Girls

UPON THE TEN COMMANDMENTS

1. Thou shalt not have another God than me:
2. Thou shalt not to an image bow thy knee,
3. Thou shalt not take the Name of God in vain:
4. See that the Sabbath thou do not profane.
5. Honour thy father and the mother too:
6. In act or thought see thou no murder do.
7. From fornication keep thy body clean:
8. Thou shalt not steal, though thou be very mean⁴.
9. Bear no false witness, keep thee without spot:
10. What is thy neighbour's see thou covet not.

THE AWAKENED CHILD'S LAMENTATION

When Adam was deceivèd,
I was of Life bereavèd;
Of late (too) I perceivèd,
I was in sin conceivèd.

And as I was born naked,
I was with filth bespaked,

⁴poor

At which when I awakèd,
My soul and spirit shakèd.

My filth grew strong, and boiled,
And me throughout defiled,
My pleasures me beguiled,
My soul! how art thou spoiled!

My joys with sin were painted,
My mind with sin is tainted,
My heart with guilt is fainted,
I wa'nt⁵ with God acquainted.

I have in sin abounded,
My heart therewith is wounded,
With fears I am surrounded,
My spirit is confounded.

I have been often callèd,
By sin as oft enthralled,
Pleasures hath me fore-stallèd.
How is my spirit gallèd!

As sin has me infected,
I am thereof detected:
Mercy I have neglected,
I fear I am rejected.

The Word I have misusèd
Good council too refusèd;

⁵wasn't

Thus I myself abusèd;
How can I be excusèd?

When other children prayèd,
That work I then delayèd,
Ran up and down and playèd;
And thus from God have strayèd.

Had I in God delighted,
And my wrong doings righted;
I had not thus been frightened,
Nor as I am benighted.

Oh! That God would be pleasèd,
T'wards me to be appeasèd;
And heal me thus diseasèd,
How should I then be easèd!

But Truth I have despisèd,
My follies idolizèd,
Saints with reproach disguisèd,
Salvation nothing prizèd.

O Lord! I am ashamèd,
When I do hear thee namèd;
'Cause thee I have defamèd,
And lived like beasts untamèd!

Would God I might be savèd,
Might have an heart like *David*;
This I have sometimes cravèd,
Yet am by sin enslavèd!

Vanity I have lovèd,
My heart from God removèd;
And not, as me behovèd,
The means of grace improvèd.

O Lord! if I had crièd
(When I told tales and lièd)
For mercy, and denièd
My lusts, I had not dièd!

But Mercies-Gate is lockèd,
Yea, up that way is blockèd;
Yea some that there have knockèd,
God at their cries hath mockèd.

‘Cause him they had disdainèd,
Their wicked ways maintainèd,
From godliness restrainèd,
And on his word complainèd.

I would I were converted
Would sin and I were parted,
For folly I have smarted;
God make me honest-hearted!

I have to grace appealèd,
Would ‘twere to me revealèd,
And pardon to me sealèd,
Then should I soon be healèd!

Whose nature God hath mended,
Whose sinful course is ended,

Who is to life ascended,
Of God is much befriended.

Oh! Were I reconcilèd
To God, I, though defilèd,
Should be as one that smilèd,
To think my death was spoilèd.

Lord! thou wast crucifièd
For sinners, bled and dièd,
I have for mercy crièd,
Let me not be denièd.

I have thy Spirit grievèd;
Yet is my life reprievèd,
Would I in thee believèd,
Then I should be relievèd.

Were but repentance gainèd,
And had I faith unfeignèd,
Then joy would be maintainèd
In me, and sin restrainèd.

But this is to be noted,
I have on folly doted,
My vanities promoted,
Myself to them devoted.

Thus I have sin committed,
And so myself out-witted;
Yea, and my soul unfitted,
To be to Heaven admitted.

But God has condescended,
 And pardon has extended,
 To such as have offended,
 Before their lives were ended.

O Lord! do not disdain me,
 But kindly entertain me;
 Yea in thy faith maintain me,
 And let thy Love constrain me!

MEDITATIONS UPON AN EGG

The egg's no chick by falling from the hen;
 Nor man a christian, till he's born again.
 The egg's at first containèd in the shell;
 Men afore grace, in sins, and darkness dwell.
 The egg when laid, by warmth is made a chicken;
 And Christ, by grace, those dead in sin doth quicken.
 The egg, when first a chick, the shell's its prison;
 So's flesh to th' soul, who yet with Christ is risen.
 The shell doth crack, the chick doth chirp and peep;
 The flesh decays, as men do pray and weep.
 The shell doth break, the chick's at liberty;
 The flesh falls off, the soul mounts up on high.
 But both do not enjoy the self-same plight;
 The soul is safe, the chick now fears the kite.

But chicks from rotten eggs do not proceed;
 Nor is an hypocrite a saint indeed.
 The rotten egg, though underneath the hen,